Key question
What was the significance of the Hamas election victory in 2006?

Key dates
Hamas victory in Palestinian elections: 2006

Israeli invasion of Lebanon: 2006

Hamas victory in Palestinian elections 2006

In 2006 elections were held for the Palestinian parliament. All adult Palestinians on the West Bank and in Gaza were entitled to vote. Up until that time, most of the seats in the parliament had been held by members of Fatah, which was the main body inside the PLO. Increasingly, however, ordinary Palestinians saw Fatah and many of the PLO leaders as corrupt and ineffective. There was widespread frustration, anger and bitterness about the poverty and squalor in which so many Palestinians lived.

Hamas won the majority of seats in the elections. Mahmoud Abbas, a member of Fatah, remained as President of the Palestinian Authority. He also maintained his contacts with members of the Israeli government but the Hamas majority in the Palestinian parliament refused to recognise the state of Israel. As a result, Israel, the USA and most European governments refused to have any dealings with Hamas. The peace process stalled yet again.

War in Lebanon 2006

In 2000, the Israelis withdrew their last troops from southern Lebanon. They had originally occupied the area in order to protect their northern border but they faced increasing guerrilla attacks from Hizbollah, a militant Lebanese organisation whose main support came from Muslims in the south. (Hizbollah was backed by Syria and the Islamic government in Iran.)

In July 2006, Hizbollah fighters crossed the border into Israel, killed three Israeli soldiers and captured two others. They then demanded the release of hundreds of Hizbollah fighters and Palestinians who were held in Israeli jails. Israel refused to agree to a swap and launched air attacks on Hizbollah strongholds, in both south Lebanon and Beirut, the capital. Hizbollah hit back by launching hundreds of missiles, from the south of Lebanon, against towns in the north of Israel.

Israeli planes bombed Beirut airport and bridges leading to Syria which they believed to be the source of Hizbollah missiles. Within a month, the death toll in Lebanon reached a thousand, mostly civilians, with nearly a million made homeless. Nearly 100 Israelis were killed. In August 2006, a ceasefire was arranged at the UN and fighting stopped. A UN peacekeeping force was sent to the Israeli–Lebanese border. The Israelis had failed to destroy Hizbollah or to recover their captured soldiers. In the Arab world, Hizbollah's 'victory' was seen as proof that a small (Islamic) guerrilla force could defeat the most heavily armed state in the Middle East. The Israel–Lebanon border remains a likely flashpoint for future conflict.